



Held Until Contested

A Taxonomy of Kerbside Parking-Space Claim-Objects and How Long Each Goes Unchallenged

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The problem

A cone or chair left in an empty bay reads as obviously temporary, yet many sit unchallenged for weeks. Which claim-objects a street treats as binding — and for how long — has not been systematically catalogued.

Research questions

- Build a working taxonomy of a street's informal parking-space claim-objects
- Establish how long each claim type survives before it is first contested
- Test whether an object's apparent formality predicts how long a block leaves it alone

Study design

- n = 341 claim-objects · 64 verge segments · 11 suburbs · weekly walk-past audit, 16 weeks
- five-category coding scheme (cone, chair, wheelie bin, stake-and-rope, other); two coders, blind cross-check
- contested = object moved, bay occupied despite it, or council notice affixed; coding scheme pre-registered, no post hoc recoding

Findings

Claim survival varied sharply and consistently by object category. Stake-and-rope claims persisted longest before first contest; road cones, shortest.



Stake-and-rope claims held a bay a median 19 days before first contest (IQR 14–26.5 days), against a 4-day median for road cones (n = 341 claims, 11 suburbs, March–June 2026).

Implications & where next

Object formality, not an object's practical grip on the bay, tracked most closely with how long a block left a claim standing. Next: testing whether a uniform, council-issued marker narrows the survival gap across categories.

Selected references

1. Sommer, R., & Becker, F. D. (1969). Territorial defense and the good neighbor. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 11(2), 85–92. doi:10.1037/h0027050
2. Ruback, R. B., & Juieng, D. (1997). Territorial defense in parking lots: Retaliation against waiting drivers. *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*, 27(9), 821–834. doi:10.1111/j.1559-1816.1997.tb00627.x
3. Shoup, D. C. (2006). Cruising for parking. *Transport Policy*, 13(6), 479–486. doi:10.1016/j.tranpol.2006.05.005
4. Ostrom, E. (2000). Collective action and the evolution of social norms. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 14(3), 137–158. doi:10.1257/jep.14.3.137

No claim-object was moved, removed, or reported to council by research staff; locations de-identified to street segment.

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“The chair was still there in week eleven.”

Median days to first contest ranged from 4 (road cones) to 19 (staked rope) across 341 logged claims.